

was meant in a pejorative sense. But mostly it was used to denote the composer's blurred harmonies or his taste for creating sound-pictures of the same kind of natural subjects that the Impressionist painters used, such as clouds, mists, or gusts of wind. As a rule, Debussy was annoyed when critics described his music as Impressionist. The movement had, after all, already passed its heyday (the last Impressionist exhibition was held in 1886).

Debussy's closest affinity to any painter was with the US artist James McNeill Whistler, who produced misty scenes of the Thames River in London. Inspired by a series of Whistler's paintings called *Nocturne*, Debussy used the same title in a musical series of *Nocturnes*, completed in 1899. He saw this music as “an experiment in the different combinations that can be created from a single color—what a study in gray would be in painting.”



*NOCTURNE, BLUE AND SILVER: BATTERSEA, 1872–1878*

James McNeill Whistler found fame with his atmospheric scenes of the Thames River in London—as in this view of Battersea in his *Nocturne* series. Debussy,